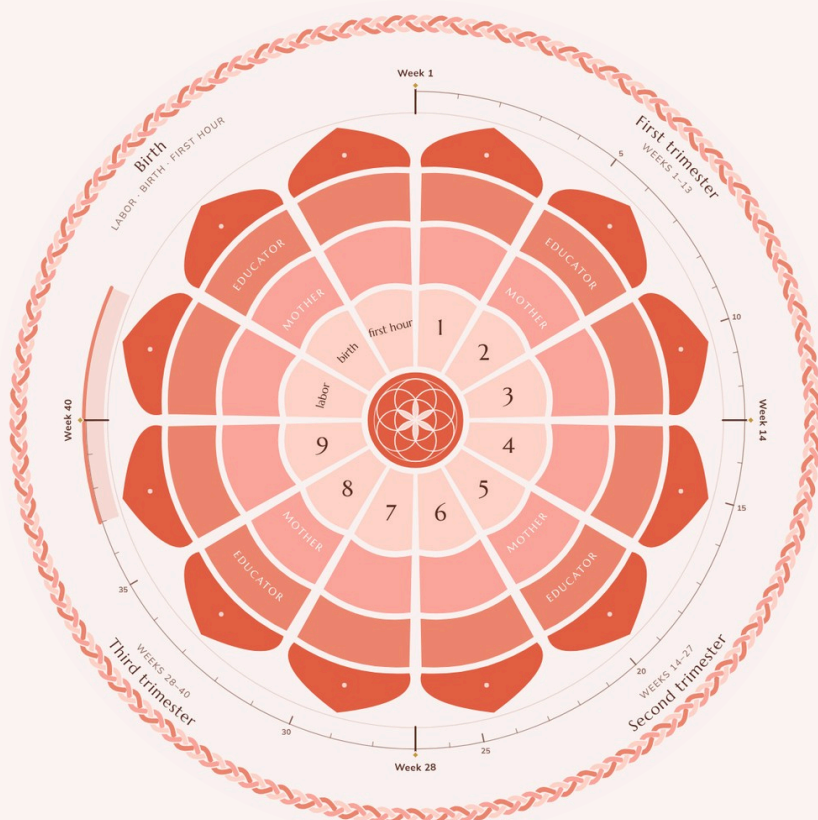


A GUIDE TO THE TWELVE CARDS



The Pregnancy and Birth Mandala

From the first days to the first hour

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A map for the journey, with a child at its heart

Pregnancy is often described in weeks, tests, and appointments. This deck invites you to see it another way: as a journey you and your baby take together, from the first days to the first hour after birth.

In pre- and perinatal education, the baby is understood as aware from the very beginning. She is taking in her world, and what she experiences in the womb, at birth, and in her first hours may leave imprints that shape her long after. This is not a weight to carry. It is an invitation to slow down, to notice, and to connect.

The cards come from a mandala, a circle organized around a center. At its center is your baby. Around her is you. Around you is what is good to know, and on the outer petals are practices for connecting with her and for your own healing.

There is one card for each month of pregnancy, and one each for labor, birth, and the first hour. This guide explains how to use them, goes deeper into each month, and points you toward people who can walk with you further.

There are no secrets you can keep from your baby, so talk to her, and more importantly, listen.

Karen Strange, Simple Tools for Mothers

One card at a time

- 1 Find your card.** Choose the card for the month you are in. The small wheel in its corner shows where it sits on the mandala.
- 2 Read the front.** It holds a short picture of your baby, of you, and of what is good to know this month.
- 3 Turn it over.** The back holds practices for connecting with your baby, with steps to follow, and one practice for your own healing.
- 4 Keep it close.** Set the card where you will see it: by your bed, on the fridge, in your bag. Return to its practices through the month.
- 5 Look ahead.** Read the next card a little before its month begins. Read the three birth cards early in the third trimester, so you have time to practice.

A few gentle notes

Share them. Many practices are for partners, too. Read the cards together.

Go at your pace. Skip a practice that does not feel right. Return to it later, or not at all.

Write it down. A small journal beside the deck can hold what you notice and what surfaces.

Ask for help. If a practice stirs more than you can hold, page 23 lists people who can help.

From the center out

The circle begins at the top with the first day of the last period and moves clockwise through three trimesters of three months each. The last quarter is birth: labor, the birth itself, and the first hour.

- **The center.** The Seed of Life, a pattern linked with creation and beginnings, holds the place of your baby.
- **The child.** Her growth and what she may be sensing, month by month.
- **The mother.** Your body, hormones, and feelings.
- **The educator.** Possible imprints, what helps, and ways to build resilience. On the cards, this is "Good to know."
- **Connecting and healing.** Practices for you and your baby, and for your own earliest stories.

The time wheel counts the forty weeks. With a date entered online, it shows today and the birth window, from 37 to 42 weeks.

The ten moons mark the true full and new moons of your pregnancy, an old way of counting its length.

The braid of three strands, for child, mother, and educator, holds the whole circle together.

Explore the full mandala online to read every month in detail and see your own moons: [\[LINK TO THE INTERACTIVE MANDALA\]](#)

The First Trimester

Beginnings



Life is often present before anyone knows it. These first weeks are full of rapid building, and of big feelings as the news arrives.

Your baby. From a cluster of cells to a moving fetus. Her heart begins to beat, every major organ begins, and the placenta takes root.

You. Hormones rise quickly, bringing fatigue, nausea, and tenderness. The news can bring joy, fear, and old feelings to the surface.

The focus. Welcome her, find one way to settle yourself, and gather the people who will support you.

When to read. As early as you can, even before you feel ready.

CARDS IN THIS SECTION

1 · The Beginning	7
2 · The Discovery	8
3 · Taking Root	9



Month 1 · The Beginning

Your baby

Pregnancy is counted from the first day of your last period, so conception happens around week 2. About a week later, the tiny ball of cells settles into the lining of your womb, and the cells that will become the placenta begin reaching toward your blood supply. In the pre- and perinatal view, her experience begins here, often before anyone knows she is there.

You

Hormones begin shifting at implantation. A missed period around week 4 is often the first sign, and some mothers notice fatigue, tender breasts, or light spotting. Life goes on as usual until the news arrives, and when it does, feelings can come all at once.

Imprints and what helps

The circumstances of conception, and whether she was hoped for, may become part of her earliest story. That story can be met without judgment. The most helpful foundation is simple: one way to settle yourself, such as grounding, and a circle of people you can turn to. If you have known loss or a long road to conceive, hope and fear can arrive together, and both are welcome.

TO EXPLORE FURTHER

David Chamberlain describes the prenaté as a conscious, sentient being, and gathered memories of the womb and birth shared by young children and adults. Ask yourself how you might welcome your baby as someone, not something, from the very start.



Month 2 · The Discovery

Your baby

Her heart begins to beat around week 6. The neural tube, the start of her brain and spinal cord, closes, and arm and leg buds appear. By week 8 every major organ system has begun, and the first touch receptors form around her mouth. She is already taking in how she is received.

You

Pregnancy hormones climb steeply, and nausea, deep fatigue, and a sharper sense of smell often peak now. Blood volume begins to rise. For many this is the month of discovery. Joy, shock, fear, and ambivalence can arrive together, and pregnancy may bring you closer to your own childhood, letting old feelings rise.

Imprints and what helps

How the news was first received may stay with her. In one study, mothers' first reactions matched feelings their grown children later recalled. Conflict with partners or parents can reach her too. What helps is a welcoming response from the people around you, and, if the news was hard, simple repair words spoken to her. Waiting for first scans is full of uncertainty. Hard feelings are natural and need no guilt.

TO EXPLORE FURTHER

Your baby senses your emotions through your body's chemistry, and later through your heartbeat, breath, and voice. Everyday stress is buffered by the placenta. It is long, unrelieved stress that matters most, and each return to calm helps (Ham and Klimo; Raffai).



Month 3 · Taking Root

Your baby

Now called a fetus, she moves, stretches, hiccups, and swallows amniotic fluid long before you can feel it. Sensitivity to touch spreads from her face across more of her body. Some of your chemistry, including stress hormones, reaches her through the placenta.

You

Nausea often eases near the end of this month as the placenta takes over hormone production, and your uterus begins to rise out of the pelvis. First prenatal visits and screenings usually happen now, and many families wait until now to share the news. Old feelings from childhood can surface in this window.

Imprints and what helps

Your own unresolved history, and the chemistry of your states, can reach her. What helps is a safe, trauma-informed space where you can share your story if you choose, and support when it feels big. How you nourish and rest yourself shapes her lifelong health, and small, steady steps count. Worry while waiting for screening results is natural, not a failure of trust.

TO EXPLORE FURTHER

Fetal programming, the idea that conditions in the womb shape lifelong health (Nathanielsz). The three models of care, technocratic, humanistic, and holistic (Davis-Floyd), and the Mother-Friendly Childbirth Initiative, to help you choose the care that fits you.

The Second Trimester



The Middle

Your baby begins to hear, you begin to feel her, and the relationship becomes something you can both sense.

Your baby. Her movements grow coordinated, hearing begins around weeks 18 to 20, and she begins to respond to voices, touch, and sound.

You. Energy often returns and your belly shows. Feeling her move can turn an idea into a relationship, and your thoughts begin to turn toward birth.

The focus. Talk, sing, and answer her movements. Choose the stories you take in, and begin exploring your own birth story.

When to read. Around weeks 10 to 13, just before this trimester begins.

CARDS IN THIS SECTION

4 · The First Flutters	11
5 · The First Sounds	12
6 · The Rhythm	13

Month 4 · The First Flutters



Your baby

Her movements grow smoother and more coordinated, and she makes facial expressions. Her inner ear and taste buds are taking shape. Her movements meet the walls of the womb, and soon they will meet your hand.

You

Energy often returns, and your belly begins to show. The placenta now makes most of the hormones of pregnancy. Some mothers, especially those who have been pregnant before, feel the first flutters. Relief and steadiness are common, and your sense of yourself begins to shift toward motherhood.

Imprints and what helps

Whether her movements are noticed and met may be one of her earliest lessons in relationship. Simple connection practices, for you and your partner, help, and a bonding program such as Pregnancy Dialogues can deepen them. As your pregnancy shows, others may share birth stories, many of them fearful. You can choose what you take in, set kind boundaries, and gather stories of births that went well.

TO EXPLORE FURTHER

Prenatal attachment, which grows as you turn your attention toward your baby. Karen Strange teaches that a baby's movements are her way of telling her story, and asks: can you slow down and be present to hear what she is saying?



Month 5 • The First Sounds

Your baby

Hearing begins. The first sounds reach her around weeks 18 to 20, and her hearing keeps sharpening through about week 25. Fine hair and a protective coating of vernix cover her skin, and sleep and wake cycles appear. Voices, music, laughter, and raised voices reach her as vibration through the womb wall.

You

Most mothers now feel movement. Relaxin softens the ligaments, and round ligament aches are common. The anatomy scan usually happens around week 20. Feeling her move can turn an idea into a relationship, and your partner can join in: a hand on the belly when she moves, a word or a song in answer.

Imprints and what helps

The sound world of your home may stay with her. In one study, grown children recalled music, laughter, and yelling their mothers also remembered. What helps is time to talk, sing, and play with her, and repair after loud or tense moments. If the anatomy scan brings unexpected news, you can ask what a result means, learn the options, and take time before deciding. Fear or grief is a natural response.

TO EXPLORE FURTHER

Your voice, carried through your own body, is the loudest and clearest sound she hears. Ham and Klimo describe a father whose "hoo, hoo" game from the fifth month led his newborn to stop nursing and turn toward his voice.



Month 6 · The Rhythm

Your baby

She begins to respond to sound, often moving or startling at a sudden loud noise. Her lungs begin making surfactant and her brain grows quickly. Her sleep is not yet divided into stages: she moves through loose cycles of rest and activity, and her brain waves are six to ten times slower than an adult's.

You

Your belly grows quickly. Back aches, heartburn, and swelling may begin, and a glucose screening is usually offered between weeks 24 and 28. Your thoughts may begin turning toward the birth, and your own birth story, and your mother's, may come to mind.

Imprints and what helps

The emotional climate over time matters most: ongoing tension or neglect, or warmth and contact. What helps is a steady rhythm of calm, a doula or childbirth class that fits you, and the rest you need, asked for in plain words. If the screening leads to a diagnosis such as gestational diabetes, it is information to guide your care, not a judgment on your body. Disappointment is natural, and it can sit beside caring well for yourself.

TO EXPLORE FURTHER

William Emerson's "elephant in the birthing room": everyone brings a birth story into the birth room. Oxytocin, the hormone of calm and connection, is easier to find in labor when it has been practiced in pregnancy (Strange).

The Third Trimester



The Ripening

Your baby grows, space grows tight, and both of your bodies prepare for birth.

Your baby. Her eyes open, dreaming sleep appears, and she comes to know your voice. Many babies settle head down, and her own lungs may help signal when labor begins.

You. Sleep grows harder and practice contractions stronger. Anticipation grows, and so can fear. Choices about position, monitoring, and induction may arise.

The focus. Slow down, plan your birth space and support, practice staying in the decisions, and prepare for flexibility, not fear.

When to read. Around weeks 24 to 27, just before this trimester begins.

CARDS IN THIS SECTION

7 · Light and Voices	15
8 · The Turning	16
9 · Ripening	17



Month 7 · Light and Voices

Your baby

Her eyes open and can sense light through your belly. She is gaining fat, practicing breathing, and moving between clear sleep states. REM sleep appears now, the active sleep linked with dreaming, and she spends much of each day in it. The voices she hears most will be familiar after birth.

You

The third trimester begins. Sleep grows harder, breath shorter, and practice contractions more noticeable, and prenatal visits come more often. Anticipation grows, and so can fear of birth.

Imprints and what helps

Fear in the room can become part of the birth: your own, your family's, or a provider's past cases. What helps is planning your birth space and choosing who will speak up for you; a doula can be a strong advocate at a hospital birth. It also helps to begin preparing for flexibility, not fear. Exploring other paths, such as a longer labor, an induction, or a cesarean, lets you meet a change as a choice rather than a collapse of the plan.

TO EXPLORE FURTHER

Sarah Buckley's four hormone systems of birth: oxytocin for contractions and love, endorphins for easing pain, adrenaline for the final pushes, and prolactin for mothering. Your rights in labor: companions, freedom to move, food and drink, and informed consent (MFCI).



Month 8 · The Turning

Your baby

She gains weight quickly and space grows tight, so her movements change from tumbling to stretching and pushing. Studies first show her responding to your voice differently from other voices, and after birth she prefers it. Antibodies cross the placenta to prepare her immune system, and many babies settle head down now.

You

Your uterus presses up under your ribs and builds oxytocin receptors for labor, and your breasts may begin leaking colostrum. Nesting energy often arrives. If she is breech, a real decision lies ahead, and you deserve full information and room to choose.

Imprints and what helps

How decisions are made about her position and birth may shape her experience, and yours. What helps is practicing how you will stay in the decisions: asking about benefits, risks, and alternatives, taking a moment, and saying yes or no. A baby doula, someone who follows your baby's journey through birth, and help planned for the weeks after birth are also worth arranging now. Feeling unsure or pressured is common, and naming it lets you slow down.

TO EXPLORE FURTHER

Breech options: waiting, gentle positioning, an external version, or a vaginal breech birth with a skilled provider (Fischbein and Freeze). Continuous monitoring in low-risk labors is linked to about 20 percent more cesareans; you can ask about listening in at intervals.



Month 9 · Ripening

Your baby

Her lungs finish maturing, and full term arrives at 39 to 40 weeks. Research suggests her own maturing lungs release a signal that helps start labor, so she may have a part in deciding when birth begins.

You

She may drop lower, easing your breath but adding pressure. Practice contractions grow stronger and your cervix begins to soften. Waiting can be hard, especially as pressure to induce grows, and you may feel ready, impatient, or afraid, sometimes all in one day.

Imprints and what helps

Timing, and who is in charge, may become part of her story. Induction and augmentation can interrupt the natural rhythm of birth, and babies may feel interrupted or intruded upon. Labor usually begins when you are both ready, and induction is a choice to weigh, not an automatic step. What helps is an informed, unhurried decision, continuous support planned ahead, and a conversation about what you would want if plans change.

TO EXPLORE FURTHER

The ARRIVE trial and elective induction at 39 weeks. Synthetic oxytocin does not act like your own and is linked to more postpartum depression and anxiety (Kroll-Desrosiers). Expressing colostrum after 37 weeks, with your provider's approval, helped milk flow sooner after birth (Singh).



Birth

The Threshold

Hormones, the space, and the people present all shape how your baby arrives and how she is met.

Your baby. Labor holds her in rhythm and pressure. Birth brings light, air, and sound all at once. The first hour brings your skin, your smell, and your voice.

You. Oxytocin, endorphins, adrenaline, and prolactin carry you through, and they flow best when you feel safe, private, and unobserved.

The focus. Guard the space, tell her what is happening, and keep her close. If plans change, stay in the decisions and offer repair.

When to read. Early in the third trimester, around weeks 28 to 34, so you have time to practice and plan before the birth window opens at 37 weeks.

CARDS IN THIS SECTION

10 · The Threshold	19
11 · Through the Gate	20
12 · The Welcome	21



Labor · The Threshold

Your baby

Contractions press and release her whole body like a long, firm embrace. Her own stress hormones surge, protecting her through each squeeze and preparing her lungs, and she receives some of your oxytocin and endorphins. Pressure, rhythm, and pause: the pace of labor becomes part of her story.

You

Oxytocin brings rhythmic contractions, and beta-endorphin eases pain and carries you inward. You labor best when you can move, eat and drink lightly, and follow your body, and when you feel private, safe, and unobserved, much like lovemaking.

Imprints and what helps

Interruptions, such as induction, augmentation, and routine interventions, may be felt by her too. What helps is a guarded space: dim light, quiet, and only people you know and trust, with no routine procedures without a reason. Pain is a normal part of labor, but suffering is something else; choosing relief is a sound choice that needs no guilt. If plans change, three things help you stay present: someone by your side, clear explanations, and time to respond.

TO EXPLORE FURTHER

Sarah Buckley's "undisturbed birth": when labor feels watched or unsafe, adrenaline rises and can slow oxytocin, and with it labor. Ina May Gaskin reminds us that labor is part of nature, and that walking and eating belong in it.



Birth · Through the Gate

Your baby

In the final push, a surge of noradrenaline makes her alert, often with wide open eyes at your first meeting. She takes her first breath, and her circulation changes course within minutes. Light, air, sound, and gravity arrive all at once.

You

Near the end, a surge of adrenaline gives you strength for the final pushes, the fetal ejection reflex. Many mothers feel a burst of energy and alertness to meet the baby. Pain medication, such as an epidural or opioids, can soften this surge, so you may both be less alert when you first meet.

Imprints and what helps

Every physiological birth event may leave an imprint, and harsh lights, noise, routine suctioning, and tight wrapping can overwhelm a newborn. What helps is a calm arrival, delayed cord clamping, and a gentle cesarean if surgery is needed. If the birth takes an unexpected turn, she can be told what is happening, held close as soon as possible, and offered repair words afterward. A birth that changed course is not a failure.

TO EXPLORE FURTHER

A vaginal birth helps clear her lungs and seeds her with your beneficial microbes; skin to skin and breastfeeding help close the gap after a cesarean. Thomas Verny on birth and early imprints. Karen Strange on rupture and repair.



First Hour · The Welcome

Your baby

Placed skin to skin, she warms, steadies her heart and breathing, and may crawl toward the breast on her own. Skin, smell, heartbeat, and your voice, now from the outside. A newborn may not know she is out, or that she made it, until she is told and held.

You

Skin to skin, oxytocin and prolactin peak. Oxytocin helps the placenta release and protects against bleeding, and prolactin begins milk and mothering. Awe, relief, exhaustion, and the first look at your baby may arrive together.

Imprints and what helps

Welcome or separation may be among her first lessons about the world. What helps is keeping you together: skin to skin, breastfeeding, and rooming-in, with newborn checks on your chest and the first bath waiting. If the golden hour does not happen, through separation or medical care, the bond is not lost. Relationships are built over time, and repair can begin as soon as you are together. Mixed feelings in the days after are natural and need no guilt.

TO EXPLORE FURTHER

Humanistic care keeps mother and baby together; taking the baby to a nursery for bathing is not part of this model (Davis-Floyd). Watch in the weeks after for lingering distress, such as flashbacks, numbness, or avoidance, and reach out for support (Seng and Taylor).

Seven threads behind every card

Most practices on the cards grow from Karen Strange's Simple Tools for Mothers. Knowing the threads behind them helps you make the practices your own.

- 1 You are her regulator.** She forms around what you feel and experience. When you settle, she learns how settling feels.
- 2 Slow down.** Grounding brings you into your body; pacing matches her slower rhythm. Her brain waves are six to ten times slower than yours.
- 3 Talk to her, and listen.** Tell her what you will do before you do it, tell her what is going on, tell her what you would like, and tell her the story of what happened.
- 4 Your feelings are yours.** She feels what you feel. Telling her "this is about me, not you" begins healthy separateness.
- 5 Oxytocin moments.** Pleasure on purpose wires her system to move from stress back to calm, and gives you a groove to return to.
- 6 Rupture and repair.** Hard moments come into every relationship. Returning, naming what happened, and reconnecting builds stronger trust than if the rupture had never happened.
- 7 Someone for her, too.** A "baby doula" follows your baby's journey through birth, the way a doula supports you.

It is not just what you do or say that matters, but how you are on the inside.

Karen Strange

People who can walk with you

The healing practices on the cards are gentle starting points. When something stirs more than you can hold, or you want to go further, these people and approaches can help.

PRACTITIONERS

Pre- and perinatal practitioners and educators work with bonding, early imprints, and birth stories. APPPAH lists trained practitioners.

Perinatal mental health specialists support anxiety, depression, and trauma in pregnancy and after. Look for the PMH-C credential, through Postpartum Support International.

Trauma-informed psychotherapists help with history that surfaces, at a pace that feels safe.

Doulas for birth and the weeks after, and a baby doula to follow your baby's journey.

Childbirth educators, bonding programs such as Pregnancy Dialogues, and **lactation consultants** (IBCLC).

MODALITIES

Prenatal and birth therapy, in the tradition of Ray Castellino and William Emerson, works with the imprints of conception, womb life, and birth, for babies, children, and adults.

Somatic Experiencing gently releases stress and trauma held in the body.

Craniosacral therapy offers light, hands-on support for parents and newborns.

EMDR helps the mind process hard memories, including a difficult birth.

Birth story listening helps you tell your story, be heard, and find meaning in it.

An educator can help you find the right fit. Choose people who listen, who leave you feeling safe, and who let you set the pace.

Help, reading, and sources

IF YOU NEED SUPPORT NOW (UNITED STATES)

National Maternal Mental Health Hotline: call or text 1-833-TLC-MAMA (1-833-852-6262).

Postpartum Support International HelpLine: call or text 1-800-944-4773.

In a crisis, call or text 988. In an emergency, call 911.

FURTHER READING

Chamberlain, D. *Windows to the Womb*.

Verny, T. *The Secret Life of the Unborn Child*.

Buckley, S. *Gentle Birth, Gentle Mothering*.

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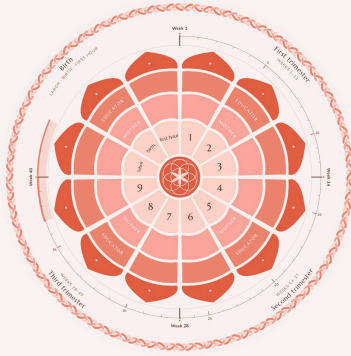
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NOTES

What I am noticing

Her movements, your feelings, what surfaced, what you want to remember.



At the center of all of this is a
child who is already present,
already listening, and already
being shaped by the world around
her.

Twelve cards and a guidebook for the journey of
pregnancy and birth, drawn from the Pregnancy and Birth
Mandala and the lens of pre- and perinatal education.

Created by Erin Singleton as part of APPPAH's Prenatal & Perinatal
Educator certification.

An educational companion, not medical advice. Talk with your care
provider about your own pregnancy.